stepped around the tiny blossoms on the slope that led up to the vines. A yellow-haired dog bounded down the hill, barking furiously until it spotted André, then wove between his legs for a good stroke on its back and belly.

A middle-aged man came down the path between the vines. “André, that was fast,” he said, shading his eyes from the sun.

“I brought an extra bike. Let me introduce you to Léa and Rose Cotillard.” André turned to the sisters. “This is Édouard LeBlanc.”

“Hello, and welcome.” Édouard smiled at them. “André thought you wouldn’t mind helping us out today with the *vendange*.” His arm swept up to the vineyards. “We’ve got a lot of grapes to pick. Do either of you have any experience picking grapes?”

“No, sir,” they both said.

“André, go down to the *chai* and find two of the smallest overalls and boots for these city girls. They can’t be working in dresses. Straw hats, too. Then you and Rose can work on the red grapes on the other side of the house, and I’ll keep Léa with me, showing her what to do. How does that sound?”

André gave a thumbs-up to Édouard, then took Rose’s hand, and together they went down to the farmhouse’s eastern wing.

Léa felt a jolt of surprise at André’s intimacy with her sister—it was as if they’d known one another for years, not just a short amount of time.

“Don’t worry—it won’t all be work,” Monsieur LeBlanc said. “My wife and daughter are tending the vegetable garden, and they’ll have a nice lunch ready for us in a few hours!”

“That’s a good incentive.” Léa smiled. “Is it hard for you to make ends meet with all the rationing and higher prices?” She wanted to probe a little and see if she could get a reaction. “I suppose the vegetables grow as well as vines in this soil, and that helps.”

“Actually, they don’t. We have a saying in the business: vines grow best when made to suffer, but vegetables need to be pampered.” He smiled. “The soil is too rocky for most of them, but my wife somehow makes them grow. It’s because of her hard work that we struggle less than others.”

When André and Rose returned with the overalls and boots, the sisters put them on, along with the straw hats.

“We’re going to work on the red grapes,” André said, picking up a basket. “Call us when lunch is ready!”